

Agentic Coding for Archives: Workshop Report

Abstract

Past Meets Future Workshop 3

HCOMP & CI

We will share outcomes of a Vibe Coding for Archives workshop hosted by the University of Maryland Center for Archival Futures (CAFe) and the University of Washington's Lab for Computing Cultural Heritage (L4CCH). This workshop, to be held in August 2026, brings together faculty and students from both research groups to share wide-ranging approaches to agentic engineering or vibe coding in the context of cultural heritage projects. CAFe is a research center focused on archives and digital curation, broadly conceived, and aiming to advance human-centered approaches to understanding and improving the use of and care for digital archives over time. L4CCH is focused on interdisciplinary approaches at the intersection of computing and digitized and born-digital cultural heritage. Projects being demoed at the workshop have used generative AI coding tools to: derive data to make oral history collections about the history of science more accessible; connect secondary resources to primary source A/V materials in a Native archive; develop an AI Lab Notebook, a Wikipedia-editing app, and the infrastructure for a digital community archive; map data into ontologies for use in a linked data platform; and more. The projects are not just about making cultural heritage work more efficient, but about creative applications of AI to open new possibilities for community access and engagement. While the primary goals of this workshop are to share approaches and outcomes and inspire our ongoing collaborative work, we also aim to explore pedagogical questions: What new skills does the emergent AI-driven paradigm of collections work demand? What foundation of knowledge do GLAM professionals need in order to undertake agentic coding in appropriate, ethical, and effective ways? The lightning talk will briefly overview the workshop and speak to the pedagogical, ethical, and pragmatic concerns that arise from participant discussions. Through this discussion we aim to (a) identify gaps in our own knowledge of this emergent space, to drive next-stage collaborative research; and (b) invite collaboration and feedback on future workshop plans or curriculum development on agentic coding for archives.